

FLYING THE GIANTS

THE LARGEST AIRPLANES THAT FLEW in the Great War were the heavy bombers the Germans called *Riesenflugzeug* ("giant aircraft"). The most famous of these "R-planes," the Zeppelin Staaken R.VI, was introduced into Germany's arsenal in September 1917, to join the smaller Gothas in their mass raids on Britain. These huge machines had two pilots sitting side by side operating steering wheels like those on airships. They also carried mechanics on

board, who tended the engines in flight. Arthur Schoeller, commander of a R.VI, wrote a vivid account of a night raid on London.

He described how 40 ground crew prepared the "giant" for action, loading the bomb bay, filling the vast fuel tanks, and tuning the four 250hp engines. After a light supper, the eight-man crew headed out to the aircraft, "whose idling engines sing a song of subdued power." Six R-planes taxied out on to the takeoff strip. Their engines at full throttle emitting a deafening roar, the heavily laden machines slowly rose into the air and headed out across the sea into black nothingness. With only calculations of time, speed, and direction to tell them where they were, Schoeller and his observer had begun to suspect they might be lost when, to their relief, they saw searchlights probing the sky: "bright beams making glowing circles in the thin

overcast clouds." They must be over England. An airfield, lit by flares for use by British night fighters, appeared startlingly bright beneath them. They bombed it in passing, while their machine-guns blasted away at the searchlights. Then, through a break in the cloud, they spotted the Thames River. Soon the observer, who had moved to the open observation post in the nose of the aircraft, was pressing the bomb-release keys, hoping to hit the London docks somewhere below. After dropping their bombload, they turned for home along the Thames with bursts of antiaircraft fire dangerously close. A shell splinter tore the fabric of the upper wing but caused no serious damage. Heading back across the sea their troubles were far from over. In sight of the Belgian coast, all four propellers stopped because of a frozen fuel line. They glided as far as dry land, where their flares lit up a cratered terrain. Schoeller stalled the aircraft just above the ground and pancaked, smashing the landing gear and a wing. His crew was safely home.

AERIAL VIEW

This in-flight view from above the Staaken R.IV's two-seater cockpit shows the open balcony at the front of the engine nacelle, top left, which was occupied by on-board mechanics.

